Nothing New Here

By Jasmine Mans, David James Hudson, and Danez Smith

Newark Riots / Black Son* by Jasmine Mans

Blood has decorated these streets
They have begun to look like pastures of rose petals.
Black boys have gotten so fed up with their prayers
  drowning by bedside,
They load their guns into the sky
to make sure God is listening

We are chalk outlines of snow angels,
We breathe like death is lurking on the edge of our spleens
We dance in the wind to the crackles of gun shells,
Jerk bodies back like God is head puppeteer of this
  destruction.

Death looks too much like children
Maybe we've been dancing on the edge

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Of God's sanity for too long.
Some casualties of genocide look too familiar

To not scream.

* "I am just afraid to raise a black son"
Who will spend the rest of his life
Praying for a melody or a melanin
Safe enough to scream in.

A boy who had to be a martyr for a war
He never asked for.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jasmine Mans
Book: Chalk Outlines of Snow Angels
ASIN: B008JHIM2Y
Publisher: Thorn10 Publishing
Date (Month/Year): July 2012

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

INTRODUCTION

In the words of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. "Darkness cannot drive out darkness; only light can do that. Hate cannot drive out hate; only love can do that." He also encouraged people to keep moving forward. He said "If you can't fly, then run; if you can't run, then walk, if you can't walk then crawl, but whatever you do, keep moving forward. Today . . . I stand. Today, I speak out.

Nothing New Here – A collection including Newark Riots and Black Son by Jasmine Mans, Another Unoriginal Poem About Police Brutality by David James Hudson and Principles by Danez Smith.

Another Unoriginal Poem about Police Brutality by David James Hudson

You have heard this poem before.

You have heard the unoriginal repetitious poetics

of a shot

of a shot

of a shot singeing the night air - of

shell casings on concrete and cases of claims of

standard police procedure - of cases of batons that

leave

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red and

white and

blue on

black and

bullets in brown bodies and

bullets in sleeping bodies and

bullets in running bodies and

bullets in bodies holding umbrellas or

holding pens or

holding other things that look like guns or

reaching for - he was

reaching for - they say she was

reaching for some expectation of dignity, service, and

protection

This is an unoriginal poem about police brutality.

You will hear the same sets of metaphors once more:

white

security, verdicts of

innocence, inconsequential bodies of

evidence, ballistics and emergency lights,

repetitious, circling around and around like
circular stories like
unoriginal poems like
a red stream of consciousness flowing through senses
punctured like
sentences punctuated with
bullet-like precision again and
again and
again and

There is really nothing new here.

This is as unoriginal as a mundane untouched sheet of
white paper or
granddad's white Klan sheets untouched in closets
beside uniforms or
uniform otherwise spotless records -
You have heard these uniform stories before, I imagine..
The same story again and
again gets old, we are
told. We'd rather plug our ears, and so
there is silence in

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waiting for
newness to
appear.
Silence:
like the eerie stillness of
prisons and profits of
plantations and poverty churned out in
steady cycles of factory-like
production - Call it run-of-the-mill:
not poetic, but prosaic
like the still persistence of
the largest private prison corporation traded
on the New York Stock Exchange - like
the silence of stock ticker tapes circulating at the
bottom
of TV screens - an economics of
morbidity - a market that demands
an endless supply of unremarkable names -
like Michael Brown
like [Trayvon Martin]
like Tamar Rice

like [George Floyd]

like [Breonna Taylor]

like -

Are you tired yet?

Then set your aesthetics aside. There is no originality
The same old stories out there mean the same old
stories here, so this will stop being cliché when that
stops being cliché -when clichés are no longer scripted in
blood stuttering like last breaths along sidewalks

Until then . . . *(*Coda to the end of the selection)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David James Hudson
ISBN: On-Line transcript (NSDA Approved Website)
https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/another-unoriginal-poem-about-police-brutality/
Publisher: Poem Hunter.com
Date (Month/Year): June 20, 2017

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FOR EDUCATIONAL

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Principles by Danez Smith

ask not what your country can do for you
ask if your country is your country
ask if your country is addicted to blood
ask if your country is addicted to forgetting
ask if your country was built of stolen land
and stolen breath, if democracy is a chain
    tight as skin around your neck
ask if your comfort means round
    the corner a man is dead cause a cop
    mistook his body for a gun
ask if your new apartment used to belong
  to someone who couldn't afford to look
  like you, ask yourself if all the things
  you are scared to admit are shovels
  slowly filling up a brown boy's throat.

all lives don't matter
the same as all lives

what my life mean to you?
am i talking to you?

do you wish me justice
or do you wish I would just
shut up already, vanish already?

why they
send bullets through our
bodies like they trying
to see if we real or just
a bad dream? why they
nightmare us into beast?
why they comfort the cops
and not the families?
why administrative leave?
why they look up the record
before they check the pulse?
why they try to spin the story
before they call the ambulance?
why they more worried about
getting caught then they worried
about the killing? why they
protect and serve themselves

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from us? why they want us to
apologize for being
in the way of they bullets?
what good is police?
what is the American dream
to a brown person
except a dream of America
leaving us alone?

i don't want America no more.
i want to be a citizen of something new.
i want a country for the immigrant hero.
i want a country where joy is as indigenous as the people.
i want a country that keeps its word.
i want a country that don't treat its people
    like a virus.
i want a country not trying to cure itself of me.
i want a nation under a kinder god
i want justice the verb not justice the dream.
i want all lives to matter.

i want peace.

i want equity.

hope is hard but i have it

let us not be idle or stunned by fear

let us not be so comfortable that we

ignore another's grieving instead

of ending what makes [them] grieve

let us not be scared of the work because

it's hard

let us move the mountain

because the mountain must move

*Until then, chalk this up as

one more outline, another empty

shell of a thing - Just one more

unoriginal poem.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Danez Smith
ISBN: On-Line transcript (NSDA Approved Website)
https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/principles-3/

Publisher: Poem Hunter.com
Date (Month/Year): Sept 21, 2016

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